FIGURE 6.1. Word cloud from Italian board statements, 2010–2012. Data come from IMF archival documents. Common stop words are removed.

Berlusconi's case exemplifies a broader phenomenon—populist leaders often publicly reject IO engagement to avoid domestic backlash, creating challenges for IOs that rely on member cooperation to function effectively. Yet, as Berlusconi's private dealings with the IMF show, overt resistance doesn't always equate to complete disengagement. IOs can sidestep public defiance by engaging populists discreetly, leveraging forums for private dialogue and collaboration.

Indeed, doing so allows populist leaders to escape public scrutiny for cooperating with elite-driven IOs. Italian prime minister Giorgia Meloni, for instance, has been described as less than a "true" populist despite her outsider status and far-right platform as a result of her willingness to work publicly with the EU; the *Economist* has referred to her as "Mainstream Meloni."[4] This could erode her appeal with populist constituents moving forward. More subtle engagement with the EU and other multilateral bodies may have limited such backlash.

Alternatively, IOs can sideline populist constituents by shifting support toward domestic nonpopulist actors. For example, the EU has withheld funds from populist-led governments like Poland's Law and Justice party, promising to release them once EU-aligned leaders assume power. This strategy bore fruit in Poland, where the center-left coalition led by Donald Tusk, a staunch EU advocate, took office in 2023.

Sidelining constituents thus offers IOs a pathway to maintain cooperation in politically fraught situations. Secrecy—the focus of this chapter's empirical analysis—allows IOs to navigate populist opposition while still delivering critical public goods. Scholars have long argued that private communication facilitates effective diplomacy, allowing leaders to bypass public posturing and reach mutually beneficial agreements (Morgenthau 1948; Krasner 1978; Stasavage 2004).

However, secrecy can also have unintended consequences. It can undermine transparency and accountability, exposing IOs to accusations of elitism and corruption. Public trust in IOs depends on visible adherence to norms and rules, and secrecy can erode this trust, creating fertile ground for populist narratives about IO overreach. Moreover, secrecy does not address